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Netbook Operating Systems

We take a look at three popular open source operating systems for netbooks.

A modern netbook is likely to have 150 GB of disk space, 1 GB of RAM, a screen resolution of 1024x800, and a wide range of connectivity options. It can hardly be called a minimalist device. Invariably, it will also be double the weight of the original EEEPC 701!

Also, a netbook screen is relatively small. Overlapping windows are a mess more often than not, and confuse users, rather than help them.

The operating system you choose for your netbook would really depend on what you want to use it for. The Ubuntu Netbook version is probably the most widely used. I opted for the 10.10 beta version with a new look and feel. MeeGo, promoted by Intel and Nokia, has been receiving a lot of attention. It boots very fast on an Atom CPU. A third option I found very exciting was KDE Plasma's Netbook Workspace. It is as simple as changing the theme on a standard desktop and the result is a very different interface.

A common element of all three is that, usually, an application is opened in the full-screen mode. Each tries to increase the viewing area by removing the window decorations.

MeeGo

MeeGo organises the screen like a set of tabbed pages, with tab icons appearing in a horizontal bar at the top. The location and meaning of each tab is fixed. For example, the *Time* tab opens a calendar. The *Applications* tab lets you choose an application to start. *Zones* shows the open applications, and lets you switch between them. The *Internet* page shows a limited number of favourite Web pages. The *People* page shows your contacts.

An application starts in full-screen mode. The horizontal bar with tabbed options is hidden. Pushing the mouse against the upper edge of the screen displays the tabbed options. The title bar of the application has only one button, 'X', to close the application. Minimising or maximising does not have any relevance.

Usage is pretty simple and uncluttered. Getting used to the interface is not hard at all. Some applications, like games, did not open in full screen mode. In some cases, but not all, F11 would change it to the full-screen mode. However, the upper edge of the screen was then no longer active, which meant that it was not possible to display the options bar. F11 had to be pressed again in order to bring the display to normal size, and resume 'normal' usage.

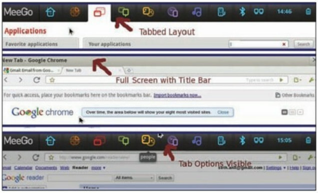

Figure 1: MeeGo top panel: a. tabbed view, b. application screen active, c. mouse at top edge so panel buttons are shown

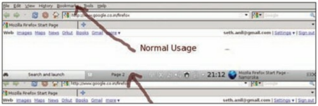

Figure 2: KDE Plasma Netbook top area: a. Firefox is active, b. Mouse at top edge so panel is visible

Since the only button available to control the window is 'X' (for closing the window), this behaviour seemed inconsistent and odd.

MeeGo uses RPM packages. A Fedora spin is in progress. Once that is available, the current limitation of the number of easily installable applications will disappear. I expect that the integration between GNOME and KDE applications and MeeGo window management will improve. It is, without doubt, an exciting interface.

KDE 4.5 Plasma Netbook Workspace

I opted for Arch Linux while exploring the KDE Plasma Netbook option; Kubuntu 10.10 beta is the easier option to explore it with. However, the Lenovo S10-3 would not boot with this version. The problem has since been resolved. The details, in case anyone is interested, are given at http://sethanil.blogspot.com/2010/09/kde-45-on-lenovo-s10-3.html.

There is an activity bar on the top. Aside from the status indicators of the netbook, it has a search and launch button. This shows you the page for selecting and starting an application. It is just like the KDE application launcher